

in retirement, whether you start tapping into your 401(k), pension, or annuity, you'll already be mentally and financially adjusted to your new reality. You're well on your way to enjoying life with a predictable amount of money flowing in, minus the low-level panic financial uncertainty breeds. Living within your means will feel natural. That's how to reach financial freedom—now.

This is a financial blueprint that suits most profiles, regardless of what income you're bringing in. It's not impossible, but it's tough. But here is the ultimate trick to building wealth and retiring in comfort and ease. It goes beyond just living within your means. You must stay within your means. As you earn more income, remain exactly where you're at. In other words, *with every exponential increase in your salary, don't match it with lifestyle spending*. Treat your increased earnings as a bonus, not a given, and certainly not as a prompt to stretch beyond your boundaries. Shave off a nice percentage that you can splurge with, but sock the rest of the money away, or pay down your mortgage. Don't get caught in the loop of living larger and larger just because you think you can. Here's one thing I know about really wealthy people: They find that set point of "enough" and then they rarely exceed it. Once they find that set point, they don't spend more extravagantly as their income increases. They bank and invest that extra money, but continue to enjoy life at the level of luxury they already defined as "enough." That extra cushion of cash provides them with enough security to weather any storm. This is something everyone should do, and that everyone *can* do, regardless of how much they have.

Money Mistake: You Don't Know How Much Money You Waste

THE FIX: CALCULATE (AND SAVE) YOUR GHOST MONEY

I love compound-interest charts almost as much as I love compound interest. There's no more tangible way to see money grow. Those charts are also a chilling way to watch money die. Ghost Money is dead money, money wasted on stupid things, money that should have